

THEGAPBRIEF · SIDE REPORT · OCTOBER 20, 2026

An AI Course for Kids Under 14: Market, Competitors, Ideas, Needs and Costs

Should Open Mind Innovations build an AI course for kids under 14 and young teens? Demand, competitors and pricing, course ideas, COPPA and safety, risks, needs, costs and a recommendation.

Assigned by Jacob Peterson. Every claim links to its source; numbers appear only where a cited source states them.

SUMMARY Bottom line

1 Demand is real; the paid gap is ages 8–13 "AI maker + AI judgment"

Kids already use AI widely (Common Sense: 81% of 9–12-year-olds use or interact with AI; 58% have used chatbots). Free school curricula cover *literacy*; paid live classes cover *coding with AI APIs*, mostly for grade 6+ with Python. A parent-trusted, project-based, safety-first course for 8–13 that doesn't require Python and doesn't put kids in an open chatbot is the clearest opening.

Common Sense 2026 · Redwood comparison

2 Recommendation: pilot small, live, cohort-based, parent-in-the-loop

Start with a 6–8 week live online cohort (ages 10–13) plus a parent companion guide, no child accounts on third-party AI tools, minimal data. Validate willingness to pay against $94.50–$485 live-class anchors before building any platform.

Edubracket price table

DEMAND Market upside and demand signals

2.1 Usage is near-universal by the teens

Common Sense (SSRS, Mar 18–26, 2026, n=1,204 ages 9–17): 86% use or interact with AI; 24% daily; 17% of 9–12 and 29% of 13–17 daily. ChatGPT is the most-mentioned tool (40%).

Common Sense

2.2 Teens: 64% use chatbots; younger teens less

Pew (Sep 25–Oct 9, 2025, n=1,458 teens): 64% ever use an AI chatbot; 57% of 13–14 vs 68% of 15–17. Usage lower in households under $30K (56%) vs $75K+ (66%), an access gap a priced product won't close on its own.

Pew Research

2.3 Parents misread how kids use AI: a teachable gap

Common Sense (late 2025): 67% of 12–17 use AI often/sometimes vs 49% of parents; kids mainly use it to search for facts (59%) and homework (55%), while parents overestimate companionship (23% think so vs 8% actual). Parent education is part of the product.

Common Sense AI Attitudes

2.4 Policy tailwind for K-12 AI literacy

Executive Order 14277 (Apr 23, 2025) set a federal policy of early AI exposure, a White House AI Education Task Force and the Presidential AI Challenge; EdWeek reports 20,000+ students took part in the first challenge.

White House EO · EdWeek, Jun 2026

2.5 No sourced market size

No credible, citable dollar size for "AI courses for under-14s" turned up. We are not estimating one.

COMPETITORS Existing competitors

3.1 Price landscape

Provider	Ages	Format	Price (as stated)
Create & Learn (AI/coding group)	K-12 by grade band	Live, max 5	$94.50 / 4×55 min; 1:1 $240 / 4
Create & Learn — Create with ChatGPT 1	Not stated on page	Private	$129 ($116.10 at 10% off) / 5 sessions
Create & Learn — AI Creators	Grades 6–12, needs Python	Live, 2–3	$485.55 (17% off $585) / 12×70 min
Create & Learn × Code.org LLM pilot	Grades 6–10	Live, up to 20	$75 / 8 sessions (fee donated)
CodeWizardsHQ	7–10, 11–13	Live	$399–$599 per course
Tynker	5–18	Self-paced	$180/yr (up to 3 kids); $468 lifetime
Outschool	3–18	Live marketplace	$12–$34 per class (homepage listings)
CodaKid	8+	Self-paced / 1:1	$29/mo; private from $249/mo
Inspirit AI	Grades 9–12	Live, 5:1	$1,400 / 25 hrs
iD Tech	13–17	Week camp	From $1,199
Codingal AI & ML	12–17	1:1, 48 sessions	Not published
Khanmigo	Kids via parent/school	AI tutor	$4/mo or $44/yr
Day of AI (MIT RAISE)	PreK–12	Free school curriculum	Free
Code.org / CodeAI	K-12	Free curriculum	Free
Google AI Quests / Be Internet Awesome	Grades 2–8 (roadshow)	Free	Free

Prices as reported by the linked pages (Edubracket read vendor sites Oct 4, 2026; Redwood Academy on Sep 28, 2026). Redwood is itself a competitor; treat its table as a vendor's comparison.

3.2 What this tells us

Free curricula (Day of AI, Code.org, Google) own in-school literacy, so selling literacy alone to schools is hard. Paid live AI classes cluster at grade 6+ and often need Python; the under-14 "build with AI, no Python" lane is thin. Self-paced apps anchor low ($180/yr); live small-group anchors at about $24–$40 per session.

Day of AI curriculum

IDEAS Opportunities and course/product ideas

4.1 Age bands

8–10: unplugged + teacher-driven demos; kids never type into a model. **10–13:** guided projects in a sandboxed, teacher-run tool; no child accounts. **13–14+:** optional own-account track, only where the tool's terms allow teens with parent consent.

4.2 Curriculum spine (6–8 weeks)

1) How AI learns from patterns · 2) Prompting as giving instructions · 3) When AI is wrong: fact-checking · 4) Fakes, voices and faces: deepfake awareness · 5) Make something: story, game, or comic with AI as a tool · 6) AI and your brain: when not to use it · 7) Demo day for parents. Mirrors topics free curricula validate (Day of AI covers verification, identity/trust, cognitive effort).

Day of AI units

4.3 Formats

Live small-group cohorts (highest trust, proven pricing); weekend workshops / camps; a parent-and-kid "family AI night" kit; later a self-paced video + printable track. Project showcase pages (no faces, first names only) drive word of mouth.

4.4 Parent angle

Sell the parent outcome: "my kid uses AI to think, not to cheat, and spots fakes." Include a parent guide each week, since parents use AI less than their kids (49% vs 67%).

Common Sense

4.5 School / club angle

Don't compete with free curriculum. Offer after-school clubs, teacher-led kits, and Presidential AI Challenge team coaching instead.

EdWeek

4.6 Safety by design

No open-ended chatbot for under-13s; teacher-operated demos or a filtered tool with logging; no companion/persona features (California's chatbot laws target exactly this); no faces or voices of kids uploaded to AI tools.

CA, Sep 10 2026

COMPLIANCE Safety, COPPA and age checks

5.1 Amended COPPA is now in force

Compliance date Apr 22, 2026. Covers services directed to under-13s: parental notice, verifiable parental consent, data minimization, a written security program and retention policy. Adds a "mixed audience" definition requiring age determination before collecting data.

Federal Register · Davis Polk

5.2 AI training needs separate consent

Disclosing kids' data to third parties to train or develop AI is "not integral" and needs separate parental consent. Practical rule: never send child-identifiable data to model vendors.

Promise Legal

5.3 School-specific COPPA rules not finalized

The FTC didn't finalize ed-tech/school authorization provisions, so school deals still rely on existing guidance and FERPA. Get counsel before selling to districts.

Federal Register

5.4 California chatbot and age-signal laws

SB 243 (companion chatbots; effective Jan 1, 2026) and, signed Sep 10, 2026, SB 1119 ("Adam's Law": audits, risk assessments, parental controls), AB 1856 (age verification signals) and AB 1159 (student data). A course that avoids companion-style bots and keeps kids off third-party AI accounts sidesteps most of this. Confirm with counsel.

CA, Oct 13 2025 · CA, Sep 10 2026

5.5 Third-party AI tools' own age terms

Most consumer AI tools set minimum ages in their terms; build lessons so kids under the tool's minimum never hold accounts (teacher drives the tool). Check each tool's current terms before launch.

RISKS Risks

6.1 Free substitutes

Day of AI says it reaches 4M+ students; Google and Code.org are free. Paid must be clearly "more": live, project-built, parent-facing.

Day of AI

6.2 Backlash and trust

EdWeek frames the AI Challenge against a growing tech backlash; one bad safety incident with a minor is existential for a small brand.

EdWeek

6.3 Regulatory drift

State kids-online laws are moving fast (California signed 13 bills on Sep 10, 2026). Budget for ongoing legal review.

CA, Sep 10 2026

6.4 Tool churn

AI tools change monthly; lessons tied to one product's UI go stale. Teach concepts, keep tool demos swappable.

6.5 Instructor quality and child safeguarding

Live classes with minors need background-checked instructors, two-adult or recorded sessions, and an incident process.

NEEDS What we would need

7.1 Team

- Curriculum lead with K-8 teaching experience
- 1–2 background-checked live instructors per cohort
- Part-time privacy/edtech counsel
- Founder/ops for parents, scheduling and support

7.2 Content

- 6–8 lesson plans, slides, printable activities, parent guides
- Project templates per age band; demo-day format
- Safety rules and a "when not to use AI" module

7.3 Platform

- Pilot: video calls + a parent-only signup/checkout (no child accounts)
- Later: a sandboxed, teacher-controlled AI tool with filtering and logs
- No third-party trackers or ad pixels on kids' pages

7.4 Compliance

- COPPA privacy notice, parent consent flow, data retention and security program
- Optional COPPA safe-harbor seal (e.g., kidSAFE, PRIVO)
- Safeguarding policy; state-law review (CA first)

7.5 Marketing

- Parent-targeted (parents buy; ads must not target under-13s)
- Free intro class / family AI night as the funnel (Create & Learn uses free intros)
- Homeschool groups, PTAs, libraries, after-school programs

COSTS Costs

8.1 Sourced cost points

- Verifiable parental consent (PRIVO): no public per-verification price; quoted as an annual flat license or per-user-acquisition fee (PRIVO)
- kidSAFE +COPPA seal: annual audits/monitoring; the official page lists no fee (kidSAFE)
- Price anchors (revenue side): $94.50–$485.55 per live course; $180/yr self-paced (Edubracket) (Redwood)

8.2 Rough ranges (assumptions, not sourced)

- Curriculum build (6–8 lessons, contractor): roughly $5K–$20K
- Instructor pay: roughly $30–$75/hour per live session
- Legal (COPPA notice, consent flow, terms): roughly $3K–$15K up front
- Pilot tooling (video, checkout, site): roughly $50–$300/month
- Background checks: roughly $30–$100 per instructor
- Paid parent ads for a pilot: start around $1K–$3K to test

These are planning placeholders; get quotes before committing.

THOUGHTS Overall thoughts and recommendation

9.1 Worth a small, cheap test

Demand signals are strong and sourced. The risk is mostly compliance and trust, not demand. Lead with a live pilot that collects almost no child data.

9.2 Positioning

"AI makers and fake-spotters": build fun projects with AI and learn to question it, for ages 10–13, parent-in-the-loop. Avoid the literacy-only school market (free) and the Python-required teen market (crowded).

9.3 Next steps

1. Write lessons 1–3 and run two free intro sessions to test interest
2. Price a 6-week cohort inside the $95–$485 band and run one paid cohort
3. Get a COPPA/state-law review before any child-facing software
4. Only then decide on a self-paced or school-club product

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